

# The PEO Competitive Landscape

How the Gusto PEO wins against every major competitor, by name. Strengths to respect, weaknesses to exploit, and the specific wedge for each. Built from field-verified intel as of mid-2026; confirm every figure against the live proposal in front of you.

## ADP TotalSource

*The biggest PEO, inside the biggest payroll company.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Massive benefits scale and carrier leverage
- Brand trust and balance-sheet stability
- Full-service breadth across HR, comp, compliance

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- No self-serve reporting; must request from assigned support
- Percent-of-payroll pricing rises every time you give a raise
- Enterprise pace and rigidity; SMB feels like a small account

## Insperity

*The premium, service-heavy incumbent.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Deep HR service model with named specialists
- Strong mid-market reputation and references
- Comprehensive compliance and risk support

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Most expensive in the category; heavy fee stacking
- Premium-shifting can hide true cost behind low headline premiums
- Built for companies that want high-touch and will pay for it

## TriNet

*The all-inclusive platform with a vertical pitch.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Genuinely strong all-inclusive platform; saved/auto-scheduled reports set the bar
- Vertical positioning resonates with target industries
- Solid benefits scale

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Vertical pitch is positioning, not product: same platform underneath
- Under-50 clients pooled to a service center, not a dedicated contact
- EPLI included but with a very high deductible

## Paychex PEO

*The closest strategic mirror: payroll base, cross-sell motion.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Large existing payroll base to cross-sell, like Gusto
- Established brand and national footprint
- Full-service PEO capability

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Older platform experience than the tech-forward tier
- Cross-sell can feel like an upsell, not a fit
- Service consistency varies

## Justworks

*The 'affordable PEO', whose price just went up.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Clean, well-loved product experience
- Strong brand with early-stage and small companies
- Simple, historically transparent pricing

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Plus tier raised ~18% to ~\$129, eroding the 'affordable' brand
- Three-WSE minimum
- Lighter on complex HR and underwriting depth

## Rippling

*The best technology in the industry, with very limited service behind it.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Best-in-class platform and integrations
- Fast, modern product experience
- Strong with tech-forward buyers

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Very limited PEO service depth
- A PEO is an employer relationship, not just software
- Modular pricing adds up quickly

## CoAdvantage

*Mid-market hustle and underwriting flexibility.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Flexible underwriting, including tougher comp risk
- Personalized mid-market service
- Structural flexibility: PEPM or percent-of-payroll

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Smaller benefits scale than the nationals
- Platform trails the tech-forward tier
- Limited brand awareness; custom-quote opacity

## Vensure

*The acquisition machine: the country's fastest-growing PEO, built by buying others.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Enormous scale, ~4M worksite employees across 100+ acquisitions
- Broad geographic and class-code appetite, including staffing
- Deep, well-capitalized parent with M&A; firepower

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Inconsistent technology: some on PrismHR, some on un-migrated legacy systems
- Pricing and service vary region to region
- Quote-driven; integration seams show in reporting

## Obsidian HR

*The Denver-local PEO: regional service, Colorado focus.*

### WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Genuinely local Colorado presence and service reputation
- Backed by ProService Hawaii: real infrastructure behind a boutique front
- Strong local relationships and brand

### WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Small benefits and comp scale next to the nationals
- Single-region footprint; hard fit for multi-state growth
- Limited technology depth and self-serve

# DecisionHR

*The mid-sized Florida-based national, underwriting-led.*

## WHAT THEY DO WELL

- Established full-service PEO, ~30,000 WSEs across ~42 states
- Backed by Bankers Financial: insurance and underwriting muscle
- Comfortable with workers' comp risk

## WHERE THEY'RE EXPOSED

- Quote-driven and opaque; traditional broker-channel motion
- Technology and self-serve trail the platform-first tier
- Brand awareness thin outside the Southeast

Not an official Gusto property. Prepared by Gabriel Revnew as part of the interview process. Competitor service-model and pricing details are field-verified as of mid-2026 and subject to change; always confirm against the actual proposal.